Gandhi. Zail Singh also felt that involvement of his political protégé Amarinder Singh would further the latter's prospects of replacing his (Zail Singh's) arch political rival Darbara Singh as chief minister of Punjab. [23]

In line with the past pattern of negotiations, the two days of talks held on 16 and 17 November appeared to have produced some results, and it was decided that an announcement along agreed-upon lines could be made. It was also decided that after getting final clearance for this from the prime minister, the home secretary would fly to Amritsar on 18 November to obtain the approval of Longowal and other senior Akali leaders, and then make the announcement over television and radio the same evening.

What happened next is narrated by P.C. Alexander,

> ...some unforeseen development took place, which prevented the formal conclusion of the proposed agreement between the government and the Akalis. Just an hour or so before the Home Secretary was to board the special plane for Amritsar, carrying with him the draft of the minutes of the talks, we had to suddenly face very strong opposition to the whole proposal from an unexpected source' [24]

The 'unexpected source' was Indira Gandhi's loyal follower Bhajan Lal, ever willing to curry favour with her at the slightest pretext. According to P.C. Alexander, Bhajan Lal, who had been informed of the proposal, in this instance adopted a 'determined' stand against giving any concessions to the Akalis on Chandigarh and water-sharing issues without adequately protecting Haryana's interests. [25]

Only a year ago, Darbara Singh had been summoned to Delhi to jointly sign an agreement with the Congress party chief ministers of Haryana and Rajasthan to withdraw a case filed by his predecessor Akali chief minister Badal in the Supreme Court. If a person like Darbara Singh could be made to do this, making a pliant loyalist like Bhajan Lal agree to the latest draft agreement should have been much easier. There were various ways of communicating to Bhajan Lal what Indira Gandhi wanted him to do, or not do, at a particular